THE PUFFER FISH

Ian Fleming's* evil globefish - also known as a puffer, blowfish, swellfish, or, in Japanese, *fugu* - is one of the most mysterious creatures of the sea. It is perhaps the world's most deadly fish, yet in Japan the honorable *fugu* is the perfect example of gourmet dining. With its lazy, almost feeble way of swimming, the puffer fish gives no hint of its deadly nature. Here is no shark knifing through the water, with gleaming jaws agape; but the poison hidden in the puffer's entrails makes it fearsome indeed. About 100 species of puffers in several closely related families can be found throughout the world. Their most obvious characteristic is their ability to change from **a** reasonable fish shape into a sphere two or three times larger. When frightened, excited, or annoyed, they gulp water, or even air, into **a** sac on the belly. It swells inside their tough, elastic skin, like an inner tube inside a tire, so as to discourage predators or intimidate rivals. When the fish feels safe, it squirts out the water or releases the air, deflating to its normal shape.

* Ian Fleming: author of the James Bond novels

EXERCISE 1: Find words or phrases in the passage which mean the same as:

COLUMN A **COLUMN B**

a) worthy of respect or admiration *(used ironically in the text)* .....

b) involving high-quality or exotic ingredients and skilled preparation .....

c) weak; lacking energy .....

d) clue; slight indication .....

e) reflecting light; softly shining .....

f) framework of the mouth to which the teeth are attached .....

g) with the mouth wide open .....

h) inside parts of the body including the stomach .....

i) frightening .....

j) acceptable; not unusual .....

k) globe; the shape of a ball .....

l) swallow very quickly and in large amounts .....

m) small bag-like structure containing air, liquid, etc., found in an animal or plant .....

n) stomach .....

o) become larger in volume and rounder .....

p) strong; difficult to tear or cut .....

q) an animal that hunts other animals for food .....

r) frighten; threaten; cause to lose confidence .....

s) force liquid, etc., out through a narrow opening, in a thin, fast stream or jet .....

t) cause to become smaller by letting the air, etc., out .....

EXERCISE 2: Choose the correct answer according to the passage.

1. In its appearance, the puffer fish . . . . . .

A) resembles a shark with its jaws open
B) looks as if it would taste delicious
C) is both extraordinary and fearsome
D) doesn't seem to be deadly
E) looks like no other creature in the sea

2. In certain situations, the puffer fish . . . . . .

A) squirts water at its rivals
B) hides its deadly nature by swimming feebly
C) can increase in size
D) will even attack sharks
E) inflicts a poisonous bite

3. Despite its deadly poison, the puffer fish . . . . . .

A) is a much favored delicacy in Japan
B) is frequently preyed upon by other fish
C) never feels safe when other sea creatures are nearby
D) prefers to attack its enemies with its teeth
E) cannot adequately defend itself

EXERCISE 3: Complete the sentences by selecting words from Column B in EXERCISE 1.

1. I thought the bill for that meal was quite……especially considering the huge portions they served.
2. After her fall, her knee……up to nearly twice its normal size.
3. The children had a lot of fun……water at each other using old liquid dishsoap bottles.
4. The chairman tried to……several of the board members into voting for him at the next election, but failed completely.
5. The……golden dome of the mosque could, on a sunny day, be seen for miles.